1998, our cooperation has touched new heights in diverse fields such as space, nuclear energy, defence, education, economy and culture. It was the first country with whom India has an agreement on nuclear energy. We need to study the independent approach and policies adopted by France on various global issues. There are many things we could emulate from such countries as we climb on to the higher rungs of the ladder as a world power. There is a dependability factor in our relationship with France. Weapon systems, equipment and technology transfers from France do not come with many conditions.

My visit to France in June 2007 as the chairman of the chiefs of staff committee was very useful. I met the chief of defence services, General Jean Louis Georgelin, and the chief of the army staff, visited the naval academy and the nuclear submarine base at Brest (they took us on board one of their nuclear submarines), and the headquarters of the special forces and the centre for planning and conduct of operations. It was a great honour to visit the First World War memorial at Neuve Chappelle. We also visited the beaches in Normandy and the Second World War memorial at Caen. France gave our nation and our armed forces the great privilege and rare honour to lead the Bastille Day parade on 14 July 2009, with a big military contingent. On this historical event, Prime Minister Manmohan Singh was the guest of honour and we had a 400-strong armed forces contingent marching impressively on the Champs Elysses in Paris. For me, as the honorary colonel of the Maratha Light Infantry, it was a proud day to see the gallant Marathas leading this parade.

India and the UK not only have historical ties but also an enduring strategic partnership and cooperation in diverse fields, including that of defence. My family ties with the British Indian Army are almost a century-old. Therefore, my official visit to the UK from 5–8 July 2005 had a special significance for me. Our army inherited the traditions, culture and customs from the British Indian Army and therefore we share many values. The visit started with the